

THE BEST GIFT

TEXT: Luke 1:24-38 (NKJV) *“Now after those days his (Zachariah’s) wife Elizabeth conceived; and she hid herself five months, saying, ²⁵ “Thus the Lord has dealt with me, in the days when He looked on me, to take away my reproach (Barrenness) among people.”*

²⁶ Now in the sixth month (Of Elizabeth’s pregnancy) the angel Gabriel was sent by God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, ²⁷ to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin’s name was Mary. ²⁸ And having come in, the angel said to her, “Rejoice, highly favored one, the Lord is with you; blessed are you among women!” ²⁹ But when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and considered what manner of greeting this was. ³⁰ Then the angel said to her, “Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. ³¹ And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bring

forth a Son, and shall call His name Jesus.

³² He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Highest; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David. ³³ And He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there will be no end.” ³⁴ Then Mary said to the angel, “How can this be, since I do not know a man?” ³⁵ And the angel answered and said to her, “The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Highest will overshadow you; therefore, also, that Holy One who is to be born will be called the Son of God. ³⁶ Now indeed, Elizabeth your relative has also conceived a son in her old age; and this is now the sixth month for her who was called barren. ³⁷ For with God nothing will be impossible.” ³⁸ Then Mary said, “Behold the maidservant of the Lord! Let it be to me according to your word.” And the angel departed from her.”

INTRO: We are entering the Christmas season. You know what that means! Right? Everyone is

preoccupied with what they are going to give to those who are closest to them. We want to give the best gifts we can afford to give! Right?

Some of you are trying to figure out how to top what we gave last year. We become our own competition in gift giving. We don't want to give a lesser gift; we want to give a greater gift. (Guy who was trying to figure out what to give his wife for their 50th Anniversary)

Scientist J. Robert Oppenheimer once said "*The best way to send an idea is to wrap it up in a person.*" The sad truth is that many times we spend enormous amounts of time and money trying to give "*The best gift*" to those we love and care about, when what they really want is us! Our time! Our attention! Our affection! They want to become a stakeholder in our lives!

So, my advice to each of us is that in all our gift giving and getting, let's not forget to open

ourselves up to those around us and allow others to do life with us.

THE BEST GIFT IN THEOLOGICAL TERMS

In Biblical terms, God did exactly what scientist Oppenheimer suggested when He gave “*The best gift,*” by wrapping Himself in flesh and blood, and appearing as Jesus, in a manger in Bethlehem. The theological word for what God did in giving “*The Best Gift,*” is “*incarnation.*”

Incarnation means, “*in the flesh.*” Jesus was the incarnation of God. Jesus was the way God sent “*The best gift*” to earth, and ultimately to the human race. When man sinned in the Garden, God’s response was that He would send a sinless human to atone for the sins of man. Because the sin man committed was a fleshly sin, it would require a flesh and blood sacrifice to atone for the sins of the human race.

A little girl said, *"Some people couldn't hear God's inside whisper, so He sent Jesus to tell them out loud."* That is what Christmas is all about, God talking to us about His great love for us, and reminding us that He put His money where His mouth is, and gave Himself in a flesh and blood body, whom we know as Jesus!

Notice three very important things:

- The Holy Ghost was to come upon Mary...
- The power of the Highest was to overshadow Mary...
- The Son of God would be the result of the arrangement between Heaven and earth...

Galatians 4:4 (KJV) ***"But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law."***

The miracle of the incarnation of Christ is that He was 100% God and 100% man simultaneously.

Think of this:

- On His Mother's side He wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus, on His Father's side He called Lazarus back to life...
- On His Mother's side it was necessary to maintain hydration, on His Father's side He offered water that would quench thirst for time and eternity...
- On His Mother's side He was thirty years old when He entered public ministry, on His Father's side He was present when the morning stars sang together and the sons of God shouted for joy... (Where was Jesus from 12-30?)
- On His Mother's side He was thirty-three and one-half years old, on His Father's side He was the Ancient of Days...
- On His Mother's side He died an early death, on His Father's side He abolished death...
- On His Mother's side He was buried in a borrowed tomb, on His Father's side He is the resurrection and the life...

- On His Mother's side He was subject to His parents, on His Father's side God gave Him a name above all other names...
- On His Mother's side He rode a donkey or walked everywhere He went. On His Father's side He rides on the wings of the wind...
- On His Mother's side He used a candle to dispel the darkness of night, on His Father's side He lit the world three days before He created the sun, moon and stars...
- On His Mother's side He could not light one room at a time, on His Father's side He will be the light of a city that is built two thousand miles square...
- On His Mother's side He could only be in one place at a time, on His Father's side He is omnipresent...
- On His Mother's side He had to rely upon the facts He could see, on His Father's side He is omniscient...

- On His Mother's side He broke under the weight of the cross, on His Father's side He is omnipotent...
- On His Mother's side He was a lamb led to His own slaughter, on His Father's side He was the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His Mother's side He did not open His mouth in His own defense, on His Father's side He possessed the power to call twelve legions of angels to His own rescue...
- On His Mother's side He tolerated injustice and aggression, on His Father's side He treads out the wine press of the wrath of God and breaks mighty armies across His knees...
- On His Mother's side He was Jesus, Mary's boy, on His Father's side He is King of Kings and Lord of Lords...
- On His Mother's side He never had his name in lights, on His Father's side He will reign forever...

- On His Mother's side He was never elected to high office, on His Father's side He will rule over Heaven and Earth...
- On His Mother's side He was of no reputation, on His Father's side every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess He is Lord to the glory of God the Father...

THE BEST GIFT IN PRACTICAL TERMS

I want us to focus today on “*The best gift*” ever given – God became Jesus and lived among us!

What does that really look like in practical terms?

The ultimate in human impossibility looked like this:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son man was given....
- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting –

Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)

- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in Bethlehem's stable...
- The Omnipotent became a dependent life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast yourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)
- He became sin, so the sinful could be forgiven...
- He was bruised, so we could be healed...
- He endured turmoil, so we could have peace...
- He was rejected, so we could be accepted...
- He came to earth, so we could bring heaven to earth...

- He became hungry, so the hungry could be fed...
- He became thirsty, so the thirsty could be satisfied...

CONCLUSION

If we want to give “*The best gift*” this Christmas, there are two ways to do it:

- Give ourselves to those closest to us...
- Give Jesus to everyone in our circle of influence...